Empress Dowager in 1908 removed the one powerful and experienced centre of power. The accession to the throne of a six-year-old, Puyi, meant another extended period of regency, which was simply not up to the task of managing a fast crumbling empire facing mounting domestic and external challenges.

The trigger for the Qing collapse came with the mutiny of troops in the industrial city of Wuhan on 10 October 1911, protesting against contracts given to foreign companies for railway construction. This was followed by province after province repudiating Qing rule and declaring themselves in favour of a republic. The monarchy tried to cope with the situation by appointing a retired general, Yuan Shikai, as Prime Minister and announcing moves towards setting up a form of constitutional monarchy. Meanwhile, various revolutionary groups banded together to set up a republican government in Nanjing with Sun Yat-sen as the provisional president on 29 December 1911. As a result of efforts made by several political figures and by some foreign interlocutors, a compromise was reached between Sun Yat-sen and Yuan Shikai. Yuan agreed to secure the abdication of the Qing emperor and to the formal setting up of a republic with himself as the provisional president in place of Sun Yat-sen. This was finally achieved with the abdication of Puyi on 12 February 1912 and the handing over of power to representatives of the people.

An interim constitution setting up a republic was adopted by the People’s Assembly in Nanjing. Yuan Shikai took office as president. However, he was never able to establish control over the whole territory of China, and warlords in control of different provinces continued to engage in armed conflict both with each other and with the central forces.

Sun Yat-sen soon fell out with Yuan and spent the next several years trying to obtain the support of Japan for another political change in China. He eventually settled in Guangzhou with the support of some southern warlords. There he went about reorganizing and consolidating the KMT as a political party and as an armed force. He set up a military training academy in Guangzhou, the Whampoa Military Academy, with Chiang Kai-shek as Commandant. Chiang would succeed Sun as the leader of the KMT after